PLSC 197 / SODA 110N: Social Data, Technology, and Artificial Intelligence

Assignment 7: Who Made This?

Assignment

For this assignment, you'll conduct a structured investigation into a specific piece of AI-generated creative content — text, image, or music — tracing it from output back through the human data it was built on, and use that chain to analyze the week's central questions about authorship, creativity, and cultural impact.

The assignment is as follows:

1. Choose **one** of the following:
    - A specific AI-generated image produced by DALL-E, Midjourney, Stable Diffusion, or the like; you can generate one yourself, or find a well-documented example online;
    - A piece of AI-generated music from a platform like Suno, Udio, AIVO, Google Flow, etc., potentially a documented case like "Heart on My Sleeve";
    - An AI-generated video, ideally one that is well-known and/or documented for how it was made [which program(s), etc.].
2. Using publicly available information about the tool that produced it – including documentation about its training data, any known lawsuits or controversies, and what human creative work it was built on – write a brief essay answering four sets of questions:
    (a) **The Data**: What human-created work was this system trained on? Who made that work, and did they consent to its use? Draw on what you know about how these systems are built from the readings.
    (b) **The Output**: What is actually novel about what was produced? Is this closer to remix, imitation, synthesis, or something genuinely new? Use the Epstein et al. framework of generative AI as "a new medium with its own affordances" to help frame your answer.
    (c) **The Attribution Problem**: Who, if anyone, deserves credit or compensation for this content: the developers who built the model, the humans whose work trained it, the person who wrote the prompt, or no one? Why or why not? Engage directly with the *NPR* article and the Epstein et al. reading.
    (d) **The Societal Stakes**: Drawing on the *Science Advances* paper on creativity and diversity, speculate on what might happen to culture if this kind of generation scales up. Are you persuaded by their concerns, or do you find them overstated?

Details

Your assignment should include a separate title page with your name, the name of the course, the name of the assignment, and the date on which it was completed / submitted. Include a copy of the content you analyzed (either in the form of an image / audio / video file, or a permanent weblink to it) as a separate appendix. The body of the written assignment should be *double-spaced*, in a conventionally-sized (11 or 12 point) font. Each written part of the assignment should be as short or long as you deem necessary; a rough target might be a total of 3-4 pages, *not* including the appendix. You need not cite any sources for this assignment, or include references, unless you choose to.

This assignment must be completed and submitted by Friday, November 6, 2026 at 11:59 p.m. ET. Submit your assignment by *creating / converting your assignment into PDF format*, and emailing it to Dr. Zorn (at `zorn@psu.edu`). Assignments received after the due date will not be accepted. This assignment is worth a possible 100 points.